

GreenThreads Operations Functional Brief

Company: GreenThreads (sustainable apparel) | Function: Operations

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AI.205: AI Integration in Business I | Prof. Jeff Eyet | 16 July 2026

1. Function Overview

At GreenThreads, the Operations team keeps products and daily processes moving so the business can deliver on its commitments to customers. The team manages purchase orders, inbound shipments, supplier relationships, inventory accuracy, store readiness, and the reporting that leadership relies on to make decisions. For the current quarter, everything centers on the Denver store opening. The team's job is to make sure the four launch products arrive on schedule, that the store is stocked and floor-ready on day one, and that any risk to the opening surfaces early enough to be fixed rather than absorbed.

Operations sits at the center of a wide set of relationships. Internally it supports the store team that needs merchandise on the floor, Finance that needs spending kept within budget, Marketing that plans the launch around product availability, HR that staffs the store, and leadership that needs a clear read on whether Denver is on track. Externally the team works with suppliers and transportation partners whose performance directly determines whether the timeline holds. Because so many groups depend on Operations, the quality of the team's coordination and communication matters as much as the physical movement of goods.

Success is measured in concrete terms. The team tracks on-time delivery rate against promised dates, inventory accuracy between recorded and physical counts, supplier performance across delivery and damage rates, budget adherence on freight and inventory spend, and ultimately whether the Denver store opens on schedule and fully stocked. The biggest challenge is the compressed timeline. Denver opens in 90 days, some products carry lead times of up to 65 days, and two of the launch items ship from Vietnam during typhoon season, which raises the odds of a delay. That combination leaves almost no slack, so the team has to stay organized, monitor shipments closely, and raise risks early rather than react after a problem has already landed.

2. Workflow Map

The table below maps the Operations function across its daily, weekly, and quarterly cadences.

Frequency	Typical Operations Tasks
Daily	• Monitor inventory levels and launch-product stock • Receive and verify deliveries against purchase orders • Track shipments and update shipment information • Flag shortages, delays, and damaged merchandise • Assign daily tasks and priorities to associates • Complete safety checks • Stock shelves and racks; recover and return misplaced merchandise

Frequency	Typical Operations Tasks
Weekly	• Review inventory, sales, and shipment reports • Review shipment volume and workload • Schedule upcoming deliveries • Communicate with suppliers and transportation partners • Review product returns and damaged merchandise • Identify departments or categories that need more merchandise • Review employee productivity and operational performance with management
Quarterly	• Support physical inventory counts • Prepare seasonal or holiday merchandise • Review team performance and update training and procedures • Review shrink and inventory accuracy results • Complete major floor changes and evaluate ways to improve the operation

The daily tasks are focused on keeping everything running smoothly, making sure the team knows what needs to be done, and handling problems as they come up. The weekly tasks shift toward reviewing performance, planning upcoming shipments, and making sure the store has enough coverage. The quarterly tasks involve larger planning responsibilities such as inventory counts, seasonal changes, team development, and finding ways to improve the overall operation. During the Denver launch, the daily shipment and inventory tracking carries the most weight, since that is where a small delay can grow into a missed opening if it is not caught early.

3. AI Opportunities

The opportunities below are classified using the MIT Sloan framework: Level 1 boosts individual productivity, Level 2 builds AI into a well-defined task or role, and Level 3 automates a production or operational process (Eastwood, 2026). They are ranked by a combination of impact and feasibility, with the highest-value, most realistic options at the top.

Rank	AI Opportunity	MIT Sloan Level	Impact	Feasibility
1	Inventory forecasting and reorder planning	Level 2	High	High
2	Predict high-risk shipments and send delay alerts	Level 2	High	High
3	Supplier reliability and performance scoring	Level 2	High	High
4	Generate weekly Operations reports	Level 1	Medium	High
5	Prioritize and schedule daily Operations tasks	Level 1	Medium	High
6	Inventory error and discrepancy detection	Level 2	High	Medium
7	Automate repetitive shipment monitoring	Level 3	High	Medium

The top two opportunities are the strongest because they attack the single biggest constraint on the launch, which is time. Both are highly feasible with tools already common in retail operations, and both directly protect the opening date.

Top Opportunity 1: Inventory Forecasting and Reorder Planning (Level 2)

AI could forecast demand for each launch product and recommend when and how much to reorder by weighing lead times, current stock, and the fixed opening date. With Denver only 90 days out and some products carrying two-month lead times, this helps managers place orders early enough to avoid empty shelves without overcommitting cash to excess stock. We estimate this saves roughly 8 to 10 hours per week that would otherwise go to manual inventory checks and order planning. It aligns directly with the team's core goal for the launch, which is keeping the four products in stock and the store ready to open on time.

Top Opportunity 2: Predict High-Risk Shipments and Delay Alerts (Level 2)

AI could review promised dates, historical delivery performance, lead times, and live shipment updates to flag the orders most likely to arrive late, then alert managers the moment a shipment slips. Because two launch products ship from Vietnam during typhoon season, early warning is especially valuable here. Instead of someone manually checking shipment status every day, the team is flagged only where attention is needed, which we estimate saves 4 to 6 hours per week and, more importantly, buys time to arrange a backup before a delay ever reaches the store. This aligns with the team's central lever for the launch, which is catching risk early enough to act on it rather than absorbing it.

A third opportunity worth noting is supplier reliability scoring, which grades suppliers on on-time delivery, damage rates, and lead-time accuracy. It saves roughly two hours per week on supplier reviews and makes those reviews more consistent and grounded in actual performance, which supports the same goal of protecting the timeline by holding suppliers accountable.

4. Risks, Guardrails, and Local Rules

Company leadership should set broad rules for privacy, security, intellectual property, and ethics, while Operations managers decide how those rules apply in daily work, since judgment is local (Eastwood, 2026). The table below sorts each risk into an executive guardrail or a local rule, with a mitigation for each.

Opportunity / Risk Area	Risk	Category	Mitigation / Rule
Inventory forecasting & reorder planning	A bad over- or under-reorder call during a one-time, time-limited launch window ties up cash or leaves shelves empty on opening day.	Local Operations rule (judgment is local)	Manager sign-off required on any AI reorder recommendation tied to the Denver opening before the order is placed.

Opportunity / Risk Area	Risk	Category	Mitigation / Rule
Shipment tracking & supplier data integration	Connecting an AI tool to external supplier systems creates security and IP exposure if the vendor is not properly vetted.	Company-wide executive guardrail (security & IP)	Mandatory IT/security review and encrypted, approved API connections before any AI tool touches live supplier or shipment data.
Inventory error detection	Error flags could be used unfairly or punitively against individual employees rather than to improve the process.	Company-wide executive guardrail (ethics)	Policy limiting AI error flags to process improvement only; human manager review required before any employee-level action.
Confidential data & overreliance	Staff may enter supplier, customer, or financial data into public AI tools, or accept an output without checking it.	Company-wide executive guardrail (privacy & security)	Only company-approved AI tools may be used; no confidential data in public systems; every AI output is treated as a recommendation and independently verified.

Risk 1: Reorder Decisions During the Launch (Local Rule)

The forecasting model could over- or under-recommend reorder quantities if it does not correctly weigh the Denver store's unusual 90-day deadline and the two-month lead time on certain products. During a one-time launch window, a bad recommendation could either tie up cash in excess inventory or leave shelves empty on opening day. This belongs to a local rule rather than a company-wide guardrail because corporate policy cannot account for the fact that this specific store, at this specific moment, has an unusual timeline and heightened stakes. The operations manager closest to the Denver launch understands that context, not headquarters. The mitigation is a local rule that any AI-generated reorder recommendation tied to the opening must be manually reviewed and approved by the store's operations manager before the order is placed. The AI proposes, and a human with situational knowledge disposes.

Risk 2: Connecting AI to Supplier Data (Company-Wide Guardrail)

Shipment tracking and delay alerts need live data feeds from supplier systems, and connecting an AI tool to external supplier data creates a security and IP exposure risk. If the vendor's platform is not properly vetted, sensitive supply-chain data could leak or be accessed improperly. This belongs to a company-wide guardrail rather than a local call because data security standards need to be consistent everywhere GreenThreads operates. A breach caused by one store's shortcut integration could expose supplier data for the whole company, not just Denver. The mitigation is to require that any AI tool connecting to supplier systems pass a company-wide IT and security review and use encrypted, approved connections before it is allowed to touch live shipment or vendor data, with no store-level manager able to bypass the review to move faster.

5. Tools and Verification

To research and pressure-test this brief, we used ChatGPT (GPT-5.5), a powerful reasoning model rather than a fast lightweight one, because the task required judgment about which AI opportunities were realistic and how to classify them by MIT Sloan level. We used it to help organize the workflow map, sanity-check the opportunity list against the GreenThreads case, and stress-test our risk categories. We did not take the output at face value. We checked it against Isra's retail operations experience and against the specific case details, including the 90-day Denver timeline, the up-to-65-day lead times, and the Vietnam typhoon risk, and we cross-referenced the assignment requirements to confirm every section was fully addressed. Following Mollick's advice, we deliberately used AI on a domain we understood well enough to catch its mistakes.

6. Conclusion

Used well, AI can help the GreenThreads Operations team catch shipment risks earlier, plan reorders around the launch timeline, cut the time spent on repetitive reports, review supplier performance more consistently, and keep the team focused on the most urgent work. We would start with inventory forecasting and high-risk shipment prediction, because the Denver store has a strict opening deadline and there is very little room for delay. At the same time, AI should stay a support tool rather than a replacement for management decisions. Anything involving suppliers, inventory, spending, safety, or confidential information should still be reviewed and approved by a manager before action is taken.

References

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